

The Fleet Street Heritage Walk

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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The Heritage Walk starts at the Dragon statue, which marks the boundary of the City of London in Fleet Street just east of the junction with Chancery Lane.

It stands on the site of the Temple Bar, which was moved for road widening many years ago, but now stands in Paternoster Square near St. Paul's Cathedral. Proceed along Fleet Street, past the Old Bank of England, now a pub. On the other side of the road is one of the few buildings in the City to survive from before the Great Fire, containing Prince Henry's Room with its fine plaster ceiling. Turn left into Chancery Lane and walk for 300 yards until you reach, on your right, the plaque commemorating the opening of the London Silver Jubilee Walkway, immediately opposite the Knights Templar pub.

Retrace your steps for 200 yards until you are past the Maugham Library, formerly the Public Record Office, on your left. Turn left into the pedestrian walkway just before the next large building and follow the courtyard, turning right with the modern Clifford's Inn on your left. Pass under the archway of the original Clifford's Inn to reach Clifford's Inn Passage. The left-hand side of this alley has a curious 'splashback', dating from the days before public lavatories.

The church of St Dunstan-in-the-West is next. It has monuments to Gog and Magog, Lord Northcliffe and Queen Elizabeth I. This is believed to be the oldest public statue in London.

The old vestry to the right of the church is now the home of the Worshipful Company of Carmen. Next to it are the London offices of DC Thomson, whose building is ornamented with ceramic tiles bearing the names of the Dundee Telegraph, Dundee Evening Post and People's Friend.

On the opposite side of the road is Hoare's Bank, which has been on this site for over 300 years. Continue across Fetter Lane.

This part of the north side of Fleet Street still preserves most of the original narrow alleys and courts dating from before the Great Fire.

Turn left into Crane Court, once the home of the Royal Society. At the far end, turn left to reach Fetter Lane

again. Cross to see the talking statue of John Wilkes, then continue to New Street Square. At the far end, turn right and continue under the arch to Gough Square, with Dr Johnson's House on your right and the talking statue of his cat Hodge at the far end. Turn right through Hind Court to emerge onto Fleet Street.

Cross and turn right for a few yards to reach Bouverie Street. High on the wall is the Fleet Street Heritage Sundial, probably the largest vertical sundial in Europe, opened in October 2021. Bouverie Street was widened in Victorian times by demolishing 62 Fleet Street, the printing office of Richard Carlile, from which he published *The Republican*. This is why *The Republican* appears at the top of the list of newspapers on the sundial.

The large building on the east side of Bouverie Street once housed the *News of the World*. Opposite, the building now occupied by the Polish Consulate was once the offices of *Punch* magazine. Almost opposite is Magpie Alley, with ceramic panels illustrating the printing industry. At the end of the alley, steps lead to a glass panel revealing the remains of the crypt of Whitefriars Priory.

Returning to Bouverie Street, the building opposite was the offices of the *News Chronicle*.

At the crossroads with Tudor Street, you will see the entrance to the Inner Temple. Turn left along Tudor Street, past the offices of the *Daily News* and the *Star*, Northcliffe House, and Carmelite House (*Daily Mail*).

Go straight across Whitefriars Street and take the next turning left. Salisbury Court is being rebuilt as new court buildings and the City of London Police headquarters. At the end of the street is the Grade I-listed Reuters building, designed by Sir Edwin Lutyens.

You are now back in Fleet Street. The building opposite was built for the *Daily Telegraph* and has a large clock from which the newspaper's name has been removed. Both it and the iconic *Express* building are being redeveloped, with their façades retained.

The walk ends at Ludgate Circus with a plaque to Edgar Wallace, crime writer and Fleet Street reporter. The River Fleet runs beneath Ludgate Circus and along New Bridge Street to the Thames.